Things You Should Know about Flying

By Kennon Dell and Christopher Scarpo

Alex; is nervous but expressive, generous but guarded. He is somewhere between 20 and manhood. He addresses the attendees at an Alcoholics Anonymous meeting

ALEX: Hi, my name is Alex and I'm an A . . . *(struggling to say it, hesitating)* . . . Aardvark. My name is Alex and I'm an ... Agnostic . . . Sorry. Hi, I'm Alex and I'm an Alcoholic.

(He considers before speaking again. A small laugh. He's troubled) Why. Well, that's easy. I'm an alcoholic because I thought that drinking would help me forget that sometimes things don't float when they're supposed to. *(beat)* But, by the grace of my Higher Power, I didn't drink today.

INTRODUCTION

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ALEX: The whole thing just happened so fast. Like *(snaps his fingers)* that. *(He speaks quickly here, moving through the sequence)* First, Jade, she's coming out of the bathroom at her parent's house and she's holding this little stick and she's saying "we're gonna have a kid" and I'm thinking, no, we're still kids. This is like a TV show or something, and you go to sleep and wake up to realize that nine months have gone by, and you're at the hospital and you're holding . . . *(There's a pause. He's holding his son)* this itty-bitty little person. Jesus. You're holding your son. *(He snaps out of it)* He was a handsome kid. Looked just like his dad, right from day one.

So, thing is, everybody else was going to Prom and applying for school and I was . . . changing hundreds of diapers and sharing pureed chicken with Teddy. And working at Taco Bell and Target. Because nobody cares whether or not you're "ready," right? You're never ready, you just have this person who depends on you and then, nothing

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else matters. Nothing. But being a dad was the first thing I was ever really good at.

So, um, the Program teaches us a lot about "making amends" with people, but I ended up getting a lot of practice before I ever started drinking. I might've been waiting my whole life to be a dad, but Jade, she, uh, she didn't do too well with the whole being a mom thing. For me, it was all about Teddy, you know? I just looked at him and realized my life meant something now. I was somebody's father. So, I tried hard to . . . umm . . . *(he falters a bit)* to forgive her when I came home to the apartment one afternoon and she was drunk, and there's some guy there. *(numb, detached)* And I'm thinking, what kind of sick joke is this? I loved her. But people make mistakes. And we were just kids, and I loved her. I loved Teddy. He was ours. And, so, we talked through it.

And I just kept forgiving. For Teddy, I think. More than for myself. I mean, I thought I was protecting him, but *(beat)* not everything floats the way that it's meant to. You know what insanity really is? It's doing the same thing over and over again and knowing absolutely what the result is going to be. But you keep doing it anyway.

And so did she. It was like being on a raft that's coming undone, but the current' s just getting stronger. I was paddling as hard as I could - but she'd leave for three, four, five, days at a time, and I'd sit all night in our matchbox of a kitchen, afraid she was dead. I was more afraid that I might be relieved if she was. I kept paddling, hard.

[One night] she passed out at the foot of our bed, with the rubber tubing still tight around her arm. And Teddy's just standing in his crib, wailing at the top of lungs. She said it was me, you know? That all of this was my fault. And I thought, how did we get here? I just kept paddling.

And then the raft came apart altogether. And I couldn't forgive again. Because she got in a car, high out of her mind, and she took him, she took Teddy with her. She

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had promised. Sworn that she wouldn't. That she'd never hurt him. But somebody up there must've been looking out for him, because the car was twisted up bad, her ribs broken, her face all smashed up, and he's just perfect. Not a scratch. And you want to hear feelings? Truth? Oh my God, the guilt. Awful guilt. What kind of father was I? There was no more forgiving.

She called me from the hospital. *(He speaks to Jade on the phone. At first, he's just listening, and then he speaks.)* "No. I am done listening to you. Our son, Jade. No, stop. You don't. You don't love me, you don't love Teddy. No. NO! You only love yourself. *(Very long beat)* I don't love you anymore. Yeah, I care more about him, you are absolutely right. He's my son, Jade. I'd do anything for him. We're going away. You need to get help."

(He comes back to the present) When you're free, you can fly. And we did, we flew, Teddy and I. We came to live here on the coast, stayed in a room at my Aunt's place. And, Jade, she got help. That's what's unbelievable. Months of rehab, meetings, just like this one. And she'd send little drawings, funny pictures for him. Notes to me, saying she was getting better, and that she knew things were over for us, but that she wanted to see him. . . How do you do what's right when nothing is? How do you answer when your three-year-old boy asks, 'Why doesn't Mommy love me anymore?"

Um, so, we were going to meet for lunch, and, Teddy, he was so excited - I was afraid she wasn't going to show, but right on time, she gets to our place and he runs up to her screaming, "Mommy, mommy." And at first, we're talking like it's a bad first date, but then I think we both started breathing and she says she likes our place and how pretty the view is, high up like this. She asks me if I'd mind going down to put quarters in the meter, she'd parked her car on the street in front of the building. And, of course, I do, and I turned back and looked up at them . . . They're standing on

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the balcony, and they're both laughing and smiling, waving at me - and I smile and wave back. She looks good, standing there, holding Teddy, and I'm thinking, just in that moment, maybe there's hope. It feels like such a long time ago, but we were a family once.

And then, everything froze. It did. Like the air had been sucked out, and the sky was as white as bones. Her arms stretch out wide, and she's holding him over the railing, like she's offering him to me or something. *(softly) "Mama 's gonna teach you how to fly."*

NO! *(Alex is very quiet for a moment, he's at his lowest point)* In the early dreams, I would almost catch him. I ran like I was on fire, but it wasn't ever fast enough. I never caught him. I've dreamt that dream a thousand times over, and I've never caught him. *(beat)*

I don't think I know, really, how to live without him. So I drink instead. When I drink, sometimes I think I can float enough for the two of us and I tell him, "hold on to dad, buddy, hold on as tight as you can and we're going to float away from here."

But it turns to black, and the water turns to sky - he's suspended there in air, there, for just a moment, his eyes wide, and blue and open. How was I supposed to catch him? My Teddy fell. And they took him away.

(He's holding Teddy) You and me, little buddy. I'm here. I love you, Teddy Bear. *(to audience)* Why am I an alcoholic? Because I'm too crazy to be sober. Because when I drink I get to see him sometimes. For just a moment. A second. You'd drink too. Believe me. *(He recomposes himself. Takes a long breath. End)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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